PROMISE & PRACTICE · DEEP DIVE · SOURCE ANALYSIS

The Lincoln–Douglas Debates — House & Divided

Lincoln vs. Douglas, Side by Side

Name: _____ **Period:** _____ **Date:** _____

WHAT I CAN DO TODAY I can read primary sources about The Lincoln–Douglas Debates — House & Divided, weigh who made each one and why, and use evidence to answer historical questions.

Directions. Two men, one question. Read each man in his own words, then line their arguments up against each other

THE SOURCES

SOURCE A · STEPHEN DOUGLAS · 1858 — The case for popular sovereignty

> *"I do not believe that the Almighty made the negro capable of self-government. … I believe this Government was made on the white basis … made by white men, for the benefit of white men. … [The people of each territory] have the right to decide the slavery question for themselves. If they want slavery, they have a right to have it."*
> *— Stephen A. Douglas, Lincoln–Douglas debates, 1858. Public domain*

— Stephen A. Douglas, Lincoln–Douglas debates, 1858. Public domain.

SOURCE B · ABRAHAM LINCOLN · 1858 — The case that slavery is wrong

> *"[The real issue] is the eternal struggle between these two principles — right and wrong … The one is the common right of humanity, and the other the divine right of kings. … In the right to eat the bread, without the leave of anybody else, which his own hand earns, [the Black man] is my equal and the equal of Judge Douglas, and the equal of every living man."*
> *— Abraham Lincoln, Lincoln–Douglas debates, 1858. Public domain*

— Abraham Lincoln, Lincoln–Douglas debates, 1858. Public domain.

YOUR WORK

QUESTION 1 — DOUGLAS STEP 1 · LINE THEM UP

In your own words: who does Douglas say should decide whether a territory has slavery, and does he think it matters morally?

_____

_____

QUESTION 2 — LINCOLN STEP 1 · LINE THEM UP

In your own words: how is Lincoln's answer different? What does he say slavery is?

QUESTION 3 STEP 2 · THE KEY DISTINCTION

Lincoln argued Douglas's real position wasn't neutral at all. Choosing not to call slavery wrong, Lincoln said, actually —

- ☐ A. treated slavery as no real wrong at all — which was itself taking a side
- ☐ B. proved Douglas secretly opposed slavery
- ☐ C. meant Douglas wanted immediate abolition
- ☐ D. had nothing to do with the Declaration of Independence

QUESTION 4 STEP 3 · YOUR JUDGMENT

Both men held views we reject today. But on the question the country actually faced — should slavery be allowed to spread? — whose argument do you find stronger, and why? Use a quote from the sources.

TEACHER ANSWER KEY — The Lincoln–Douglas Debates — House & Divided

QUESTION 1 — DOUGLAS: Open response.

Look for a response along the lines of: "Douglas says… and he thinks the morality…"

QUESTION 2 — LINCOLN: Open response.

Look for a response along the lines of: "Lincoln says… He calls slavery…"

QUESTION 3: **Correct — A. treated slavery as no real wrong at all — which was itself taking a side**

Right. Lincoln's point: if you say you 'don't care' whether slavery spreads, you've already decided it's not a serious wrong. Neutrality, to Lincoln, was a side.

QUESTION 4: Open response.

Look for a response along the lines of: "I find ___'s argument stronger because… As he put it, "…" ."